LOST AT SEA – Survival Activity

You are adrift on a private yacht in the South Pacific. Because of a fire of unknown origin, much of the yacht and its contents have been destroyed. The yacht had all navigational equipment destroyed while you and the crew were trying to bring the fire under control. Your best estimate is that you are approximately one thousand miles south/southwest of the nearest land.

Below is a list of fifteen items that are intact and undamaged after the fire. In addition to these articles, you have a serviceable rubber life raft with oars large enough to carry yourself, the crew, and all the items listed below. The total contents of all survivors' pockets are a package of cigarettes, several books of matches, and five one-dollar bills.

Your task is to rank the 15 items below in terms of their importance to your survival, with 1 as most important and 15 as least important. Avoid arguing for your own individual judgments. Approach the task based on logic. Avoid changing your mind if it is only to reach agreement and avoid conflict. Support only solutions with which you can agree at least somewhat. Avoid 'conflict-reducing' techniques such as majority vote, averaging or trading-in reaching your decision. View differences of opinion as a help rather than a hindrance in decision-making.

ITEMS

_____Sextant

_____Small transistor radio

_____Shaving mirror

_____Shark repellent

_____5 gallons can of water

_____20 sq. of opaque plastic

_____Mosquito netting

_____1 case of rations

_____Maps of the area

_____Seat cushion (flotation device)

_____2 gallons can of oil/gas mixture

_____1 quart of 160 proof rum

_____15 ft. of nylon rope

_____2 boxes of chocolate bars

_____Fishing kit

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Answer Sheet

Correct Order of Necessity
Most Important to Least Important

1. Shaving mirror: Vital for signaling air/sea rescue.
2. 2 gallons can of oil/gas mixture: Vital for signaling - the mixture will float and could be ignited (when the raft is clear, obviously!)
3. 5 gallons can of water
4. 1 case of rations: Provides basic food.
5. 20 sq. of opaque plastic: To collect rainwater and provide shelter
6. 2 boxes of chocolate bars: A reserve food supply
7. Fishing kit: Ranked lower than the chocolate bars because there is no guarantee that you will catch any fish!
8. 15 ft. of nylon rope: May be used to secure equipment to prevent it from falling overboard.
9. Seat cushion (flotation device): A lifesaver if someone falls overboard.
10. Shark repellent
11. 1 qt. of 160 proof rum: Contains 80% alcohol - enough to serve as antiseptic for injuries; of little value otherwise; will cause dehydration if drunk.
12. Small transistor radio: Of little value as there is no transmitter.
13. Maps of the area: Worthless without navigational aid - it does not really matter where you are, but where the rescuers are!
14. Mosquito netting: There are no mosquitoes out at sea.
15. Sextant: Relatively useless without tables and a chronometer.

The basic reason for ranking signaling devices above the life sustaining items (food and water) is that if you cannot signal there is almost no chance of being spotted and rescued. As most rescues occur during the first 36 hours, food and water are less important during that period. According to the 'experts' the basic supplies needed when a person is stranded in mid-ocean are articles to attract attention and articles to aid survival until rescuers arrive. Articles for navigation are of little importance; even if a small life raft could reach land, it would be impossible to store enough food and water to subsist during that period of time. Therefore, of primary importance are the shaving mirror and the 2 gallon can of oil/gas mixture. These items could be used for signaling air/sea rescue. Of secondary importance are items such as water and food - chocolate bars.